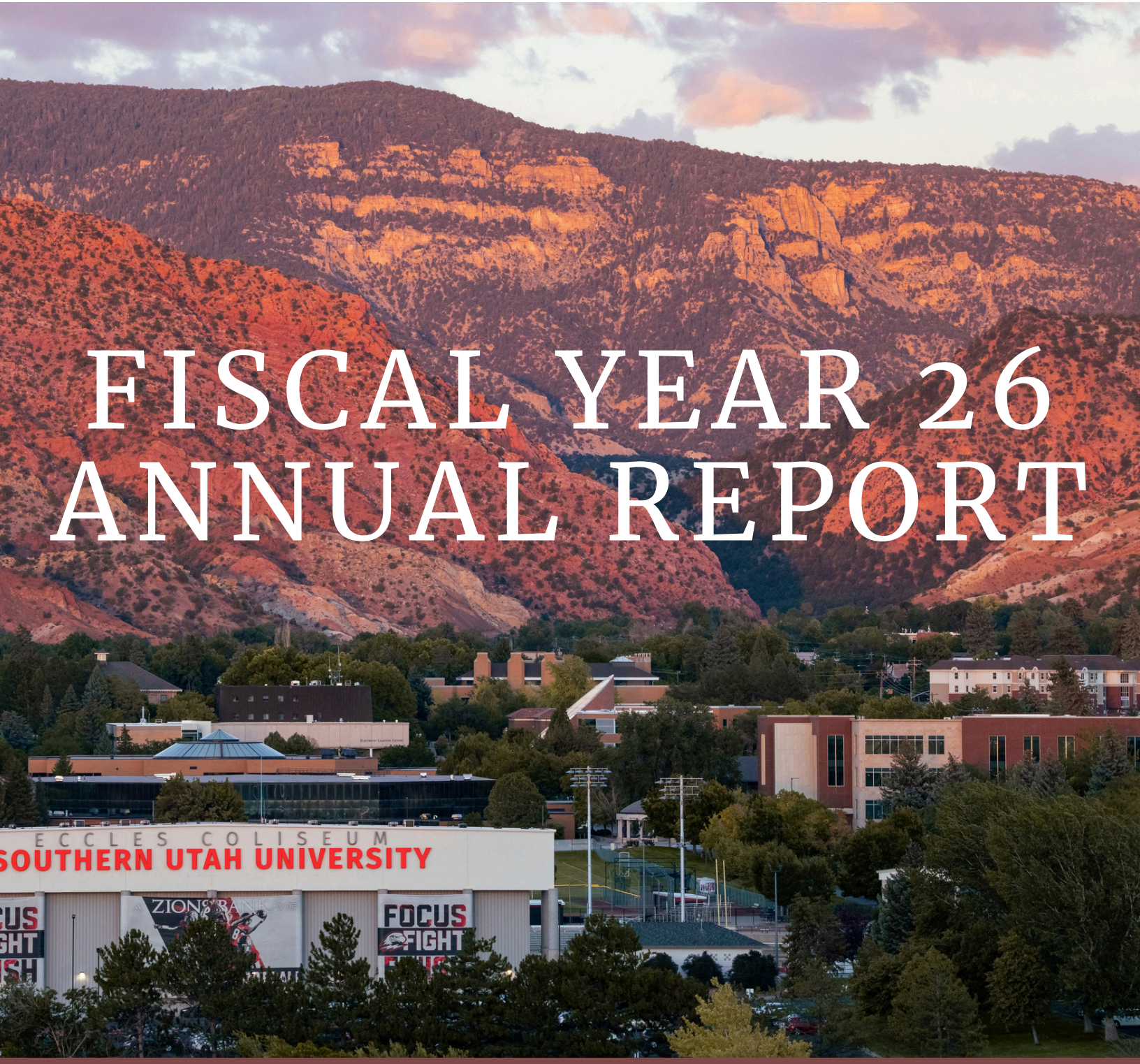


FISCAL YEAR 26 ANNUAL REPORT

SPARC

OFFICE OF SPONSORED PROGRAMS, AGREEMENTS, RESEARCH, AND CONTRACTS

INTRODUCTION 02

SUBMISSIONS 08

AWARDS 12

MODIFICATIONS 20

EXPENDITURES 23

NEWS & INITIATIVES 25

SPARC TEAM 29

About Us

SPARC can help you *SOAR*!

SPARC (**S**ponsored **P**rograms, **A**greements, **R**esearch and **C**ontracts) — your ultimate partner in the pursuit of helping your ideas *SOAR*!

Mission Statement: SPARC empowers SUU faculty, staff, and students with trusted, responsive support for research and creative activity. We foster ethical and innovative practices, build capacity through grants, and encourage professional growth and lifelong learning.

Vision Statement: SPARC will be a national leader in research administration among PUIs while driving engagement and growth at SUU. We envision faculty and staff stepping forward with confidence, supported to pursue opportunities, advance their careers, and contribute to a culture of ethical, innovative, and collaborative discovery.

Message from the Director

SPARC Executive Director, Sylvia Bradshaw

Southern Utah University continues to show what's possible when determination meets creativity. In another year of uncertainty in the national funding landscape, our faculty and staff submitted 135 proposals requesting more than $36 million, secured $16.1 million across 89 new awards, and put nearly $17 million in sponsored funds to work on campus and in our communities. Private submissions rose again, from 30 to 37, a sign that you are broadening your funding partnerships. It is an honor to serve and celebrate your accomplishments.

This was also a year of growth for the SPARC team. I am proud to announce two well-earned promotions. **Carrie Childs** has been elevated from Associate Director of Post Award to Director of Post Award Services, and **Nathan Wiggins** has moved from SPARC Data Scientist to Director of Research Analytics. Carrie's steady leadership keeps our awards compliant and well managed, and Nathan's work is putting AI and data tools in the hands of the people who need them. **Elliani Decker**, formerly our Pre-Award Research Administrator, is now our Research Development Officer. We also welcomed two new full-time Sponsored Program Managers, **Jenn Burton** and **Megan Heisz**, and added three students to our Research Analytics Team. Growing talent from within, and from our own student body, is central to how we work.

SPARC has also kept pushing forward. We completed an NCURA self-study, advanced the PROSPER PUI and AI4RA projects, and launched the Research Stole initiative to honor graduating students for their research and scholarly activity.

T**o our faculty and staff** — If you haven't yet, I invite you to get to know our exceptional SPARC team. We're here to help you find the funding and support that move your ideas forward, from proposal development to management after award, so you can focus on teaching, discovery, and creating impact.

To our students — You are the reason we do what we do. Research and creative activity are woven into your experience at SUU, and we'd love to connect you with the mentors and opportunities that make that possible.

Thank you for the opportunity to walk alongside you. Together, we're building a culture of discovery and innovation that reaches far beyond our campus.

Always Forward!

Sylvia Bradshaw

Leadership Messages

Director of Post Award Services
Carrie Childs

After many years in SPARC and Accounting Services, I see the value in the work that happens after an award is made. That success comes down to the team we have here. **Jenn Burton** and **Megan Heisz** recently joined **Courtney Wessling** and **Michelle Anderson** as Sponsored Program Managers, and our student SPMs continue to bring so much energy and fresh perspective. Through PROSPER PUI, we introduced the Sponsored Program Manager Support Selection tool, and working with our **R**esearch Analytics Team, we are automating tasks like effort reporting and budget availability reports so faculty can spend less time on paperwork. Thank you to our PIs, Accounting Services, the Budget Office, and Internal Audit for being such good partners. We're so grateful to work alongside you and look forward to everything we'll accomplish together this coming year.

Director of Research Analytics
Nathan Wiggins

The establishment of the Research Analytics Team at SUU has set our university apart as an innovative institution, and our very own SUU students are receiving national attention for their efforts to solve problems within research administration using artificial intelligence. As the new Director of Research Analytics at SUU, it has been extremely rewarding to mentor students as they approach opportunities that have challenged this field for many years with confidence and produce amazing results. **Owen Chadwick**'s automated tool for effort reporting streamlines a compliance process that used to take hundreds of hours. **Josi Bartholomew**'s research interests and grant matrix provide the foundation for connecting faculty to research opportunities like never before. Even in the short weeks since their onboarding our newest additions have made an immediate impact, with **Jane Willden** creating a program manager menu web app, **Santhosh James** designing a web app for budget availability reports, and **Dohyeon Im** streamlining our required training tracking. I look forward to continuing to work with and learn from these RATs as they help SPARC SOAR to even greater heights!

Research Enterprise

- What is Research Administration?

Research administration is inclusive of **all types of sponsored programing.** Research is any systematic investigation designed to develop or contribute to generalizable knowledge. It involves disciplined inquiry to find answers, solve problems, or create new understandings. This can include programmatic or community projects that support the local region, state, country, or the world.

- What is the research enterprise?

See the graphic below for a summary of everything that comprises the research enterprise.

- ## Why do SPARC offices exist?

With the increasing complexity of research projects and the growing demand for accountability and transparency in research (and other sponsored) funding, the role of research administrators has become more important than ever before.

- ## How does SPARC help with compliance?

SPARC stays up to date on federal, state, and sponsor regulations and institutional policies. By doing so, we hope to guide faculty and staff through the complex world of compliance both at the pre-award and post-award stages.

- ## How do teaching institutions fit into the research enterprise?

Teaching institutions enhance the research enterprise by introducing students to research, fostering partnerships, and addressing community-focused issues. Through collaborations and integrating research into teaching, these institutions broaden impacts, enrich the curriculum, and help develop a future research workforce.

- ## What has SPARC been doing to support the research enterprise?

This report highlights SPARC's recent efforts to contribute to SUU's engagement in sponsored activity and the national research enterprise. Primarily, SPARC has been successful in applying for and being awarded several grants that will be used to help SUU faculty and staff with their sponsored project engagement!

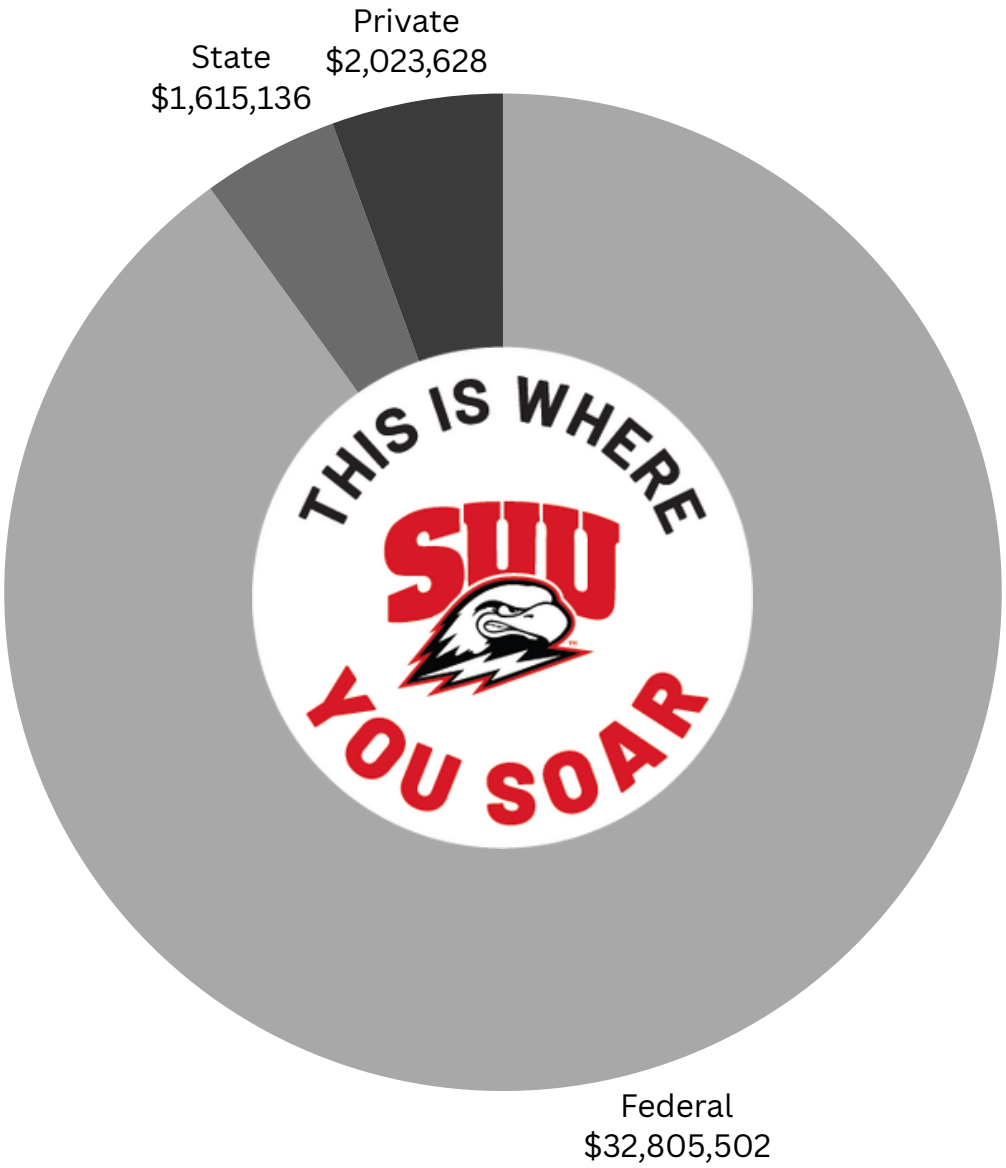
Submissions

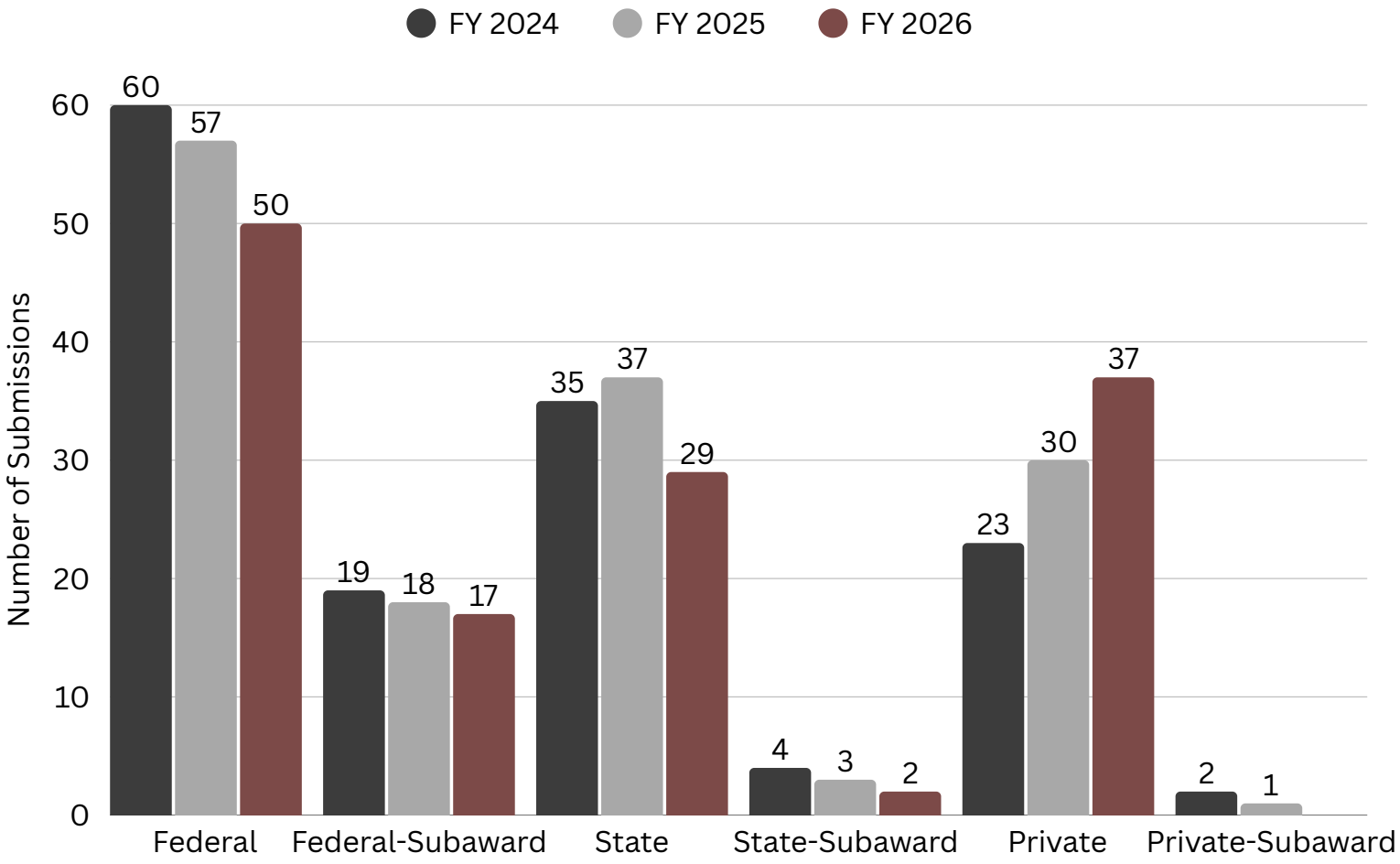
Funding Requested

$36,444,267

of Submissions

135





Proposal Highlights

- The **College of STEM** had the most submissions (**30**) in academics
- **Outdoor Pathways** had the most non-academic submissions (**16**)
- **33 departments** made a total of **135 submissions** for funding
- The highest-valued proposal was the **Headstart 2025–2029** project, submitted by Jennifer Heyborne for **$6,504,536**

PROPOSAL SUBMISSIONS

By Department for FY 26 (7/1/25-6/30/26)

Academic Faculty & Staff Submitters

Business
David Ryan 1st
Shubhashrita Basu 1st
Roderick He
Xinglong Ju
Shankar Parajulee 1st

Biology
Rachel Bolus
Marcos Corchado-Sonera
Xiaoben Jiang
Aspen Manning 1st
Dillon Monroe
Angela Patino-Acevedo
Gina Profetto 1st
Bill Heyborne

Chemistry & Physics
Richard Medina
Elizabeth Pierce 1st
Matthew Weeg
Arianna Harrington
Mackay Steffensen
Christopher Johnson
Shao Qiu 1st

Computer Science & Cybersecurity
Shalini Kesar

Education & Human Development
Pamela Powell
Mallory Poole
Nichole Wangsgard

Engineering & Technology
Mohamed Askar
Matthew Roberts
Scott Munro
Glen Sagers
Prosenjit Chatterjee
Jacob Bishop 1st
Isabella Borisova 1st
Richard Cozzens
Lance Richman 1st
Ali Siahpush

Frehner Museum
Dylan Kirklin 1st

Geosciences
Jamie Spinney 1st

Health Sciences
Suzanne Young
Jacob Manning 1st
Tony Oliver

Humanities & Social Sciences
Rosalyn Eves 1st
Doug Murdoch 1st
Sangjun Park
Josh Brown 1st
Diane Darling 1st

Office of the Provost
Melinda Pfundstein
Janet Johnson
Michelle Lambert
Tami Shugart
Melynda Thorpe

Performing & Visual Arts
Jed Blodgett
Rebecca Bloom
Jason Moodie 1st

Non-Academic Submitters

Advancement and Enrollment Management
Kurt Harris
Joshua Anderson
Joni Anderson
Ginny Swain 1st
Carrie Torgersen
Jon Oglesby

Campus Operations
Wyatt Robinson 1st

Head Start
Kari Adamson 1st
Jennifer Heyborne

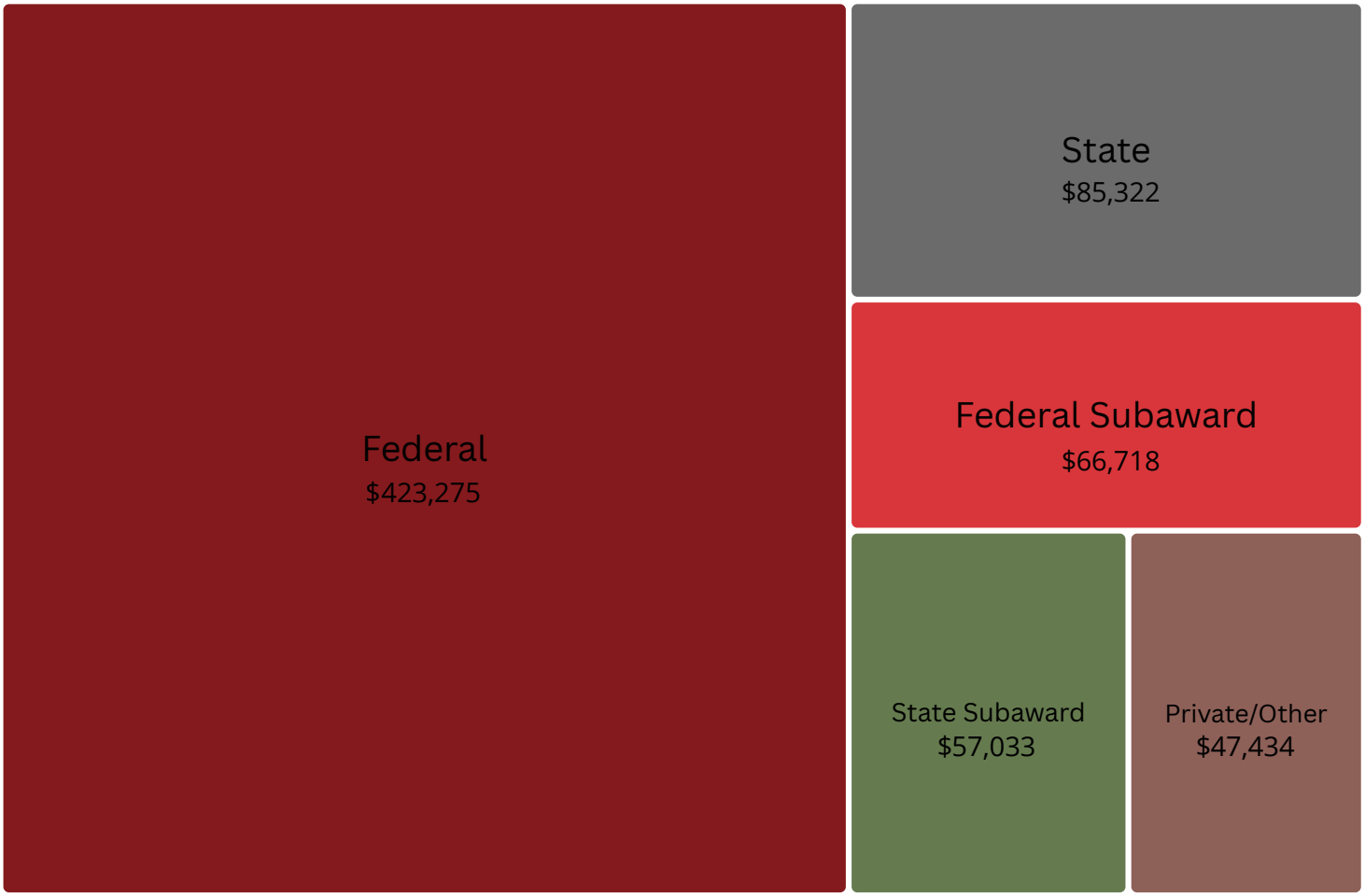
Office of the President
Emily Cacho
Britteny Corry 1st

Student Affairs
Kristy Morgan 1st
Tayzha Huxford

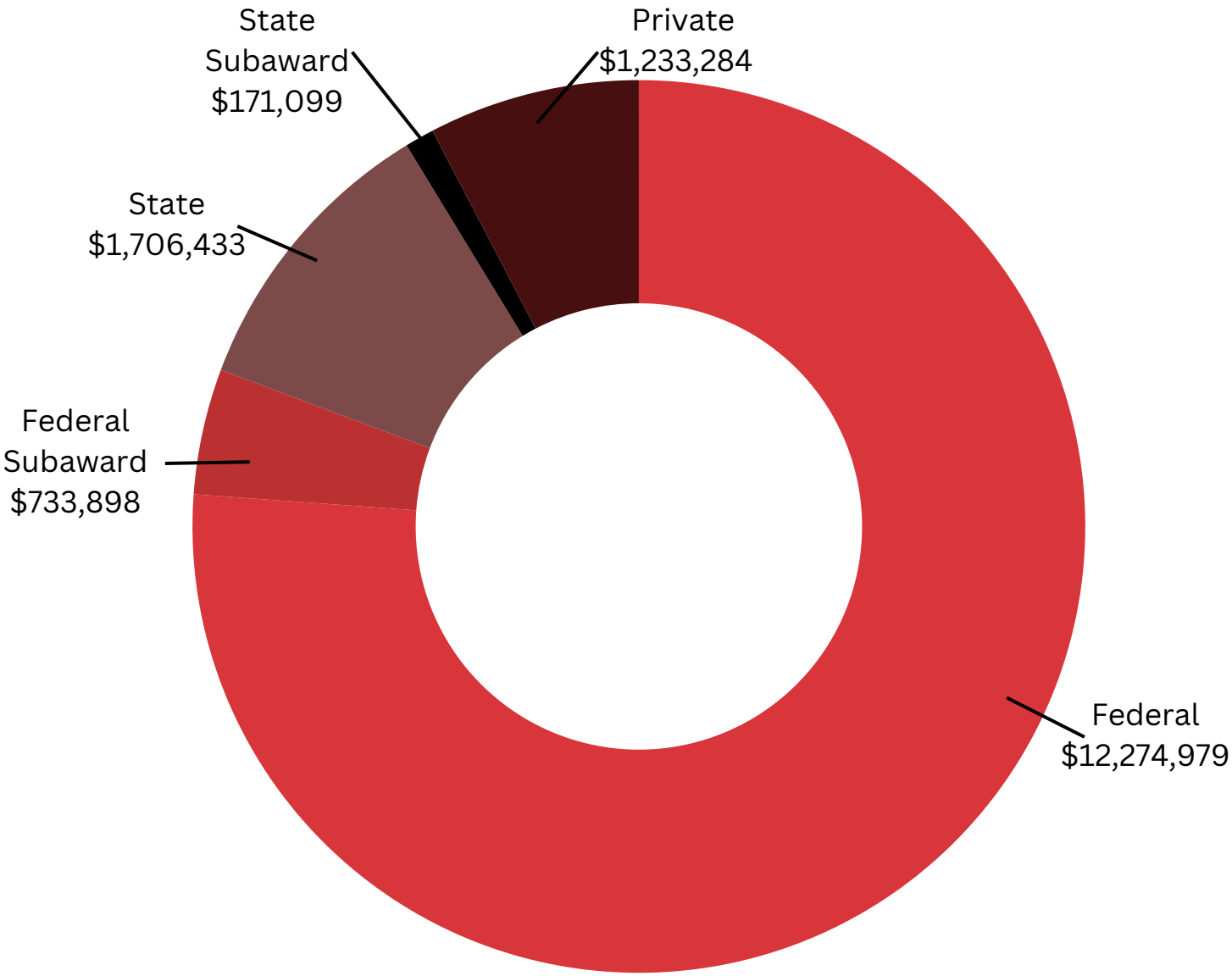
FIRST TIME SUBMITTER

Awards

During the reporting period, a total of **$16,119,693** was awarded across **89** awards. These awards reflect the strength of SUU's research and sponsored activities, spanning multiple disciplines and departments. The awarded projects range from small seed grants to large multi-year agreements, showcasing our continued commitment to *innovation*, *collaboration*, and *impact*. This funding supports research, student success initiatives, institutional support, and community engagement projects.



Average Award Size by Sponsor Type During FY26. Displays the mean funding amount per award given by each sponsor category.



*Totals include awarded proposals and modifications submitted during FY26.

Sponsor & Award Highlights

- Highest number of awards by sponsor (federal): **Department of Agriculture** and **National Parks Service**
- Highest number of awards by sponsor (state): **Utah State Board of Education** and **Utah Office of Outdoor Recreation**
- Highest funded academic college: **College of STEM**
- Highest funded non-academic department: **Outdoor Pathways**

New FY26 Awards

Any Awards after 6/30/26 will be captured in the FY27 report

ACADEMIC DIVISIONS

Science, Technology, Engineering, & Mathematics

- **Marcos Corchado-Sonera** - *Rutgers - SUU MOU*, Rutgers University, $40,000
- **Angela Patino -** *STEM AC - Hydroponics*, Utah Department of Cultural & Community Engagement, $43,000
- **Jessica Pullan** - *NIH SuRE First: Chemical Engineering of Exosomes for Enhanced Glioblastoma Therapy: Undergraduate Biomedical Research at Southern Utah University*, National Institutes of Health, $643,766
- **Glen Sagers** - *Talent Ready Utah - Computer Science RFP*, Utah System of Higher Education, $173,397
- **Mohamed Askar** - *DOE Community Energy Innovation Prize: Collegiate Track Submission*, Department of Energy, $5,000
- **Masoud Malekzadeh** - *Deep Tech Ongoing Funds - Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning for Engineering Applications Certificate*, Utah System of Higher Education, $117,566
- **Scott Munro** - *Talent Ready Utah - Civil & Mechanical Engineer RFP*, Utah System of Higher Education, $356,346
- **Scott Munro** - *TRU Mechanical Engineering Consortium Co-op Pilot Program*, Utah System of Higher Education, $12,679
- **Dylan Kirklin** - *Keeping Momentum and Building Opportunities in Southern Utah*, Utah Division of Arts & Museums, $27,980
- **Dylan Kirklin** - *Expand Access to STEM Resources - Makerspace*, Utah STEM Action Center, $4,992
- **Dylan Kirklin** - *Society for Science Fair Fund 2026*, Society for Science, $3,700
- **Dylan Kirklin** - *Southern Utah Science and Engineering Fair*, Utah STEM Action Center, $5,000
- **Jamie Spinney** - *Virtual Reality Field Trips*, National Geographic, $4,940

Education & Human Development

- **Alisa Petersen** - *BTSALP 26*, Utah State Board of Education, $65,043
- **Mallory Poole** - *Level Up in SPED Project*, Utah State Board of Education, $35,000
- **Jennifer Heyborne** - Baby Watch Early Intervention Program 2025, Utah Department of Health, $485,944
- **Jennifer Heyborne** - USDA Headstart Reimbursement, Utah State Office of Education, $387,211

Health Sciences

- **Justin DeBlauw** - *JuicePlus - Study and Analysis*, JuicePlus+, $106,767

Performing & Visual Arts

- **Jed Blodgett** - *2026 TRCC Iron County Restaurant Tax Cooperative Funding*, Iron County Restaurant Tax Board, $30,940
- **Jed Blodgett** - *The Satellite Salon Concert Series TRT*, Iron County, $5,000
- **Becky Bloom** - *Elevating Capacity and Best Practices at Southern Utah Museum of Art*, Utah Division of Arts & Museums, $92,184
- **Becky Bloom** - *Iron County TRCC Board 2025 Project Funding Program - Exhibition Funding*, Iron County, $10,000
- **Becky Bloom** - *SUMA TRCC Marketing*, Iron County Restaurant Tax Board, $60,000
- **Becky Bloom** - *SUMA TRT*, Iron County, $37,800
- **Whitney Staheli** - *Cedar City RAP TAX SUMA - 25-26*, Cedar City, $58,300

Office of the Provost

- **Janet Johnson** - *Increasing CE QL Earned Credit Award Academic Year 2025-26*, Office of the Commissioner of Higher Education, $125,000
- **Michelle Lambert** - *Perkins V FY26 - Strengthening Career and Technical Education,* Utah State Board of Education, $324,672
- **Melynda Thorpe** - *OHV and Natural Resources Law Enforcement and Management Survey*, Utah Office of Outdoor Recreation, $4,100

Business

- **Jon Lee** - *VITA*, Internal Revenue Service, $14,370

New FY26 Awards

Any Awards after 6/30/26 will be captured in the FY27 report

VP STUDENT AFFAIRS

Career & Professional Development Center

- **Kristy Morgan** - *SUU Pre-ETS 2026 Grant*, Utah Department of Workforce Services, $1,199,620

Student Support Services

- **Ashleigh Zimmerman** - *Student Success Services TRIO Program*, Department of Education, $352,531

New FY26 Awards

Any Awards after 6/30/26 will be captured in the FY27 report

VP ADVANCEMENT & ENROLLMENT MANAGEMENT

Learning Abroad

- **Kurt Harris -** *SPARK - Summer Program for Academic Research and Cultural Knowledge - SUU 2026*, Eurasia Foundation, $33,270

Small Business Development Center

- **Joni Anderson** - *StartUp Cedar - The Nucleus Institute*, Nucleus Institute, $150,000

Utah Center for Rural Health

- **Carrie Torgersen** - *Medical Student Placements*, Rocky Vista University, $100,000
- **Tyler Watson** - *Recruiting, Training, and Retaining a Robust Behavioral Healthcare Workforce in Rural Utah*, Health Resources & Services Administration, $1,350,000

Outdoor Pathways

- **Joshua Anderson** - *2026 Pipe Springs NM-NPF - Youth Agreement*, National Park Service, $20,000
- **Joshua Anderson** - *BLM Color Country - NON-Renewable Resources*, Bureau of Land Management, $18,000
- **Joshua Anderson** - *BLM Color Country - Renewable Resources*, Bureau of Land Management, $68,000
- **Joshua Anderson** - *Dixie Nat Forest and Kanarra Falls Trail Crew - Intergovernmental Internship Cooperative (IIC) - Non-Motorized*, Utah Office of Outdoor Recreation, $199,993
- **Joshua Anderson** - *Dixie National Forest - (BAER) Burn Area Emergency Rehab*, Department of Agriculture, $107,288
- **Joshua Anderson** - *Dixie National Forest - Timber Sale Prep, Department of Agriculture*, $368,000
- **Joshua Anderson** - *Forest Wide Trail Maintenance,* Department of Agriculture, $368,000
- **Joshua Anderson** - *IIC & Fishlake Nat. Forest OHV Motorized Trails Crew*, Utah Office of Outdoor Recreation, $71,541
- **Joshua Anderson** - *Iron TrailCraft, Inc*, Iron TrailCraft, Inc, $15,323
- **Joshua Anderson** - *OHV Trail Maintenance - USFS Dixie*, Utah Office of Outdoor Recreation, $176,620
- **Ashley Tyler** - *USDA, Forest Service: Forest Inventory and Analysis - 2025*, Forest Service, $500,000

New FY26 Awards

Any Awards after 6/30/26 will be captured in the FY27 report

OFFICE OF THE PRESIDENT

Utah Shakespeare Festival

- **Emily Cacho** - *Cedar City RAP TAX USF - 25-26*, Cedar City, $130,000
- **Emily Cacho** - *Utah Shakespeare Festival TRCC Infrastructure*, Iron County Restaurant Tax Board, $100,000
- **Kami Terry Paul** - *Utah Cooperative Marketing Grant 2025*, Utah Office of Tourism, $100,000
- **Britteny Corry** - *Utah Shakespeare Festival TRT*, Iron County, $100,000

Photo: Utah Shakespeare Festival

FY26 Award Modifications

Any Award Modifications after 6/30/26 will be captured in the FY27 report

Modifications or amendments are adjustments to previously funded awards. When additional funds are provided, it may require effort similar to the proposal submission process. For instance, if a project receives an extra $50,000 each year over three years, these funds may be considered modifications.
There is an extensive amount of work and time that is also expended on non-monetary modifications such as no-cost extensions, PI changes, etc.

Athletics

- **Alyssa Davis / Travis Illian** - *Sports Nutrition Grant*, Dairy West, $18,100

Academic Divisions

- **Annette Apple** (Teacher Education) - *USBE - STEM Endorsement Incentive Program,* Utah State Board of Education, $105,180.09
- **Daniel Hatch** (Psychology) - *SUU - ICSD PsyD Intern*, Iron County School District, $26,880
- **Dylan Kirklin** (STEM Center) - *Cedar High School Tutors*, Iron County School District, $20,000
- **Mohamed Askar** (Engineering & Technology) - *DOE Community Energy Innovation Prize: Collegiate Track Submission*, Department of Energy, $21,000
- **Mohamed Askar** (Engineering & Technology) - *Educating Southern Utah Hydropower Pioneers (ESUHP)*, Department of Energy, $5,000
- **Geosciences** - *Horse Butte Raptor Fatality Surveys*, Martin and Nicholson Environmental Consultants LLC, $10,066.66
- **Dylan Kirklin** (STEM Center) - *Iron County School District - CVHS*, Iron County School District, $1,260
- **Ali Siahpush** (Engineering & Technology) - *NASA K-12 Workshop - Utah Space Grant Consortium*, University of Utah, $3,000
- **Dylan Kirklin** (STEM Center) - *STEM Community Impact Sponsorship*, Utah STEM Action Center, $1,200
- **Ali Siahpush** (Engineering & Technology) - *Utah Space Grant Consortium - 2025-2028*, University of Utah, $18,000

Academic Divisions *(continued)*

- **Jennifer Heyborne** (Headstart) - *Headstart 2025-2029 Year 3*, Department of Health and Human Services, $3,293,573
- **Jennifer Heyborne** (Headstart) - *Headstart Training 2025-2029 Year 3*, Department of Health and Human Services, $29,327
- **Melynda Thorpe** (Workforce Development) - *MOU - National Judicial College - Development of two online educational modules*, National Judicial College, $67,258.66
- **Tami Shugart** (ETS) - *ETS Program 2020-21*, Department of Education, $366,934
- **Sylvia Bradshaw** (SPARC) - *ER2: Scaling Open Access Responsible and Ethical Conduct of Research (RECR) and Research Mentoring (RM) Trainings from R1s to PUIs*, University of Utah, $7,250
- **Eric Fielding** (Upward Bound) - *Upward Bound*, Department of Education, $517,162

VP Advancement & Enrollment Management

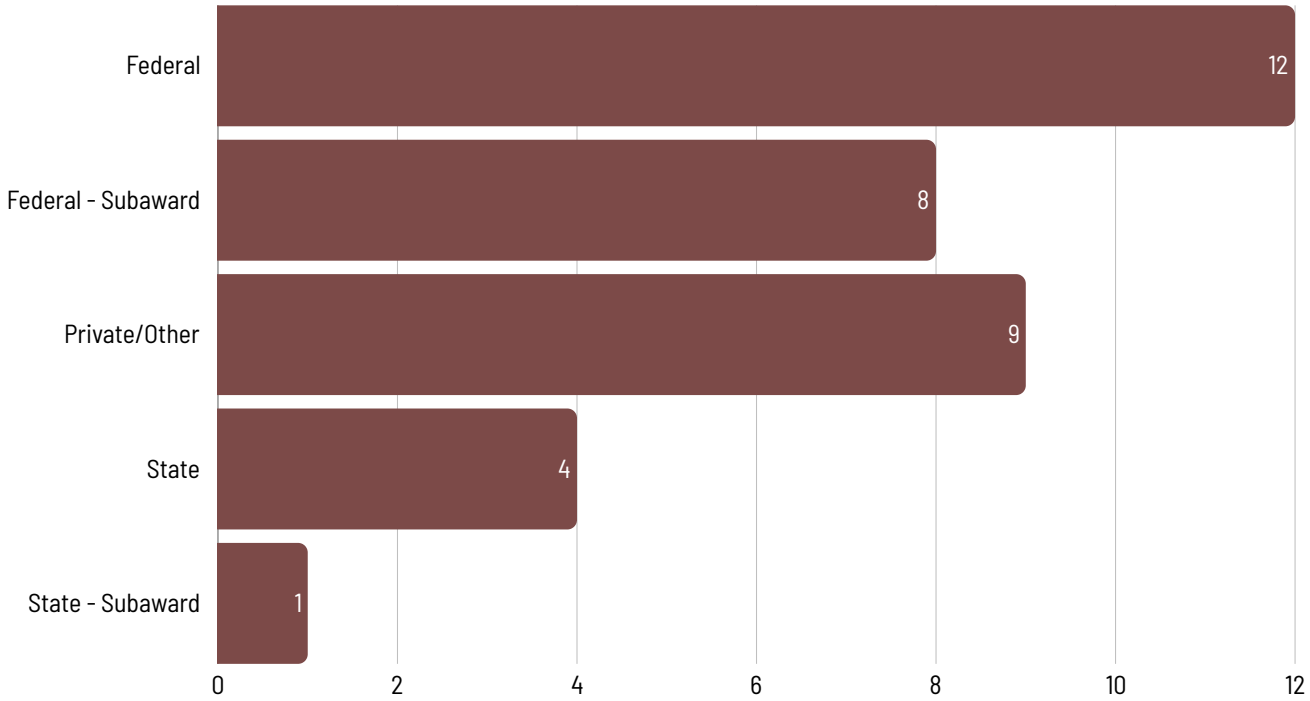
- **Kurt Harris** (Learning Abroad) - *Summer Program for Academic Research and Cultural Knowledge (SPARK)*, Eurasia Foundation, $6,422
- **Joshua Anderson** (Outdoor Pathways) - *Geographic Resource Center, Denver NPS GIS Program*, National Park Service, $134,677
- **Joshua Anderson** (Outdoor Pathways) - *IIC - Garfield County*, Garfield County, $22,500
- **Joshua Anderson** (Outdoor Pathways) - *Kanab - Office Youth Internship*, Bureau of Land Management, $210,000
- **Joshua Anderson** (Outdoor Pathways) - *Kanarra Falls Trail Maintenance Position*, Town of Kanarraville, $6,800
- **Joshua Anderson** (Outdoor Pathways) - *Red Cliffs Desert Reserve - Washington County*, Washington County, $9,256
- **Joshua Anderson** (Outdoor Pathways) - *USDA, Dixie NF - Eco Job Training 2024-2029*, Forest Service, $15,000
- **Joshua Anderson** (Outdoor Pathways) - *ZION2025 Youth Agreement*, National Park Service, $143,000
- **Joni Anderson** - *Small Business Development Center 2025*, Utah State University, $75,000
- **Alexus Erickson** (Utah Center for Rural Health) - *Substance Abuse Prevention Grant 2024*, Southwest Utah Public Health Department, $60,065

VP Advancement & Enrollment Management *(continued)*

- **Alexus Erickson** (Utah Center for Rural Health) - *UROHC-Coordinated Care Model*, University of Utah, $100,106
- **Tyler Watson** (Utah Center for Rural Health) - *Rural Dental Recruitment Program*, University of Utah, $126,099
- **Tyler Watson** (Utah Center for Rural Health) - *Utah Area Health Centers (AHEC)*, University of Utah, $120,908.25
- **Carisa Wood** (Utah Center for Rural Health) - *Nurse Education, Practice, Quality and Retention-Clinical Faculty Preceptor Academies (NEPQR-CFPA)*, Montana State University, $65,207

VP Student Services

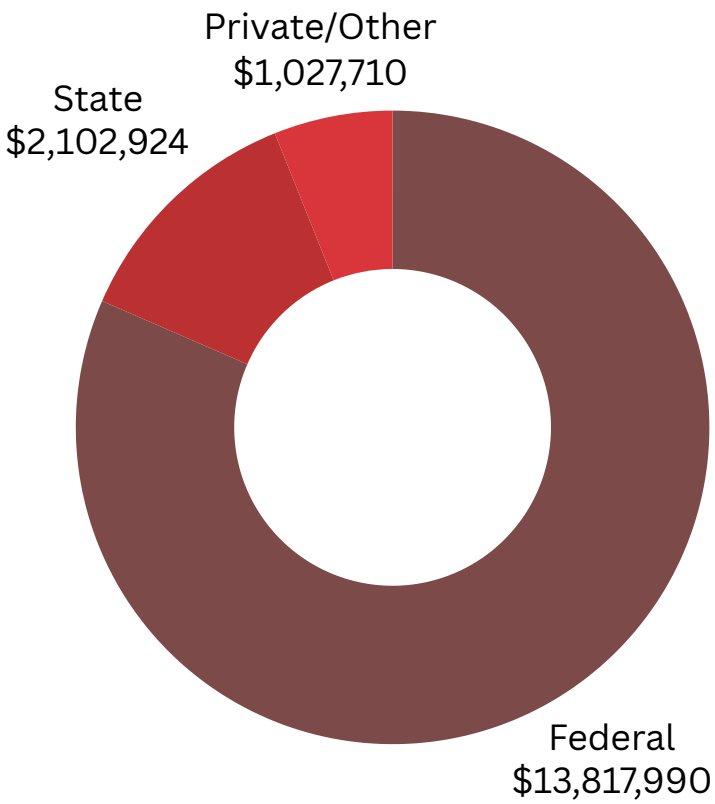
- **Tayzha Huxford** (Child Care Center) - *SUU CCAMPIS 22*, Department of Education, $447,865
- **Madison McBride** (Health & Wellness) - *GLS Campus Suicide Prevention*, Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration, $142,076.48
- **Jeff Hunt** (Veterans' Resource & Support Center) - *Veteran Student Support Centers Grant Proposal 24-25*, Utah Department of Veterans and Military Affairs, $12,100



FY26 Number of Modifications by Sponsor Type. A total of 34 monetary modifications were received during FY26. This does not include modifications such as budget re-allocations or no cost extensions.

Expenditures

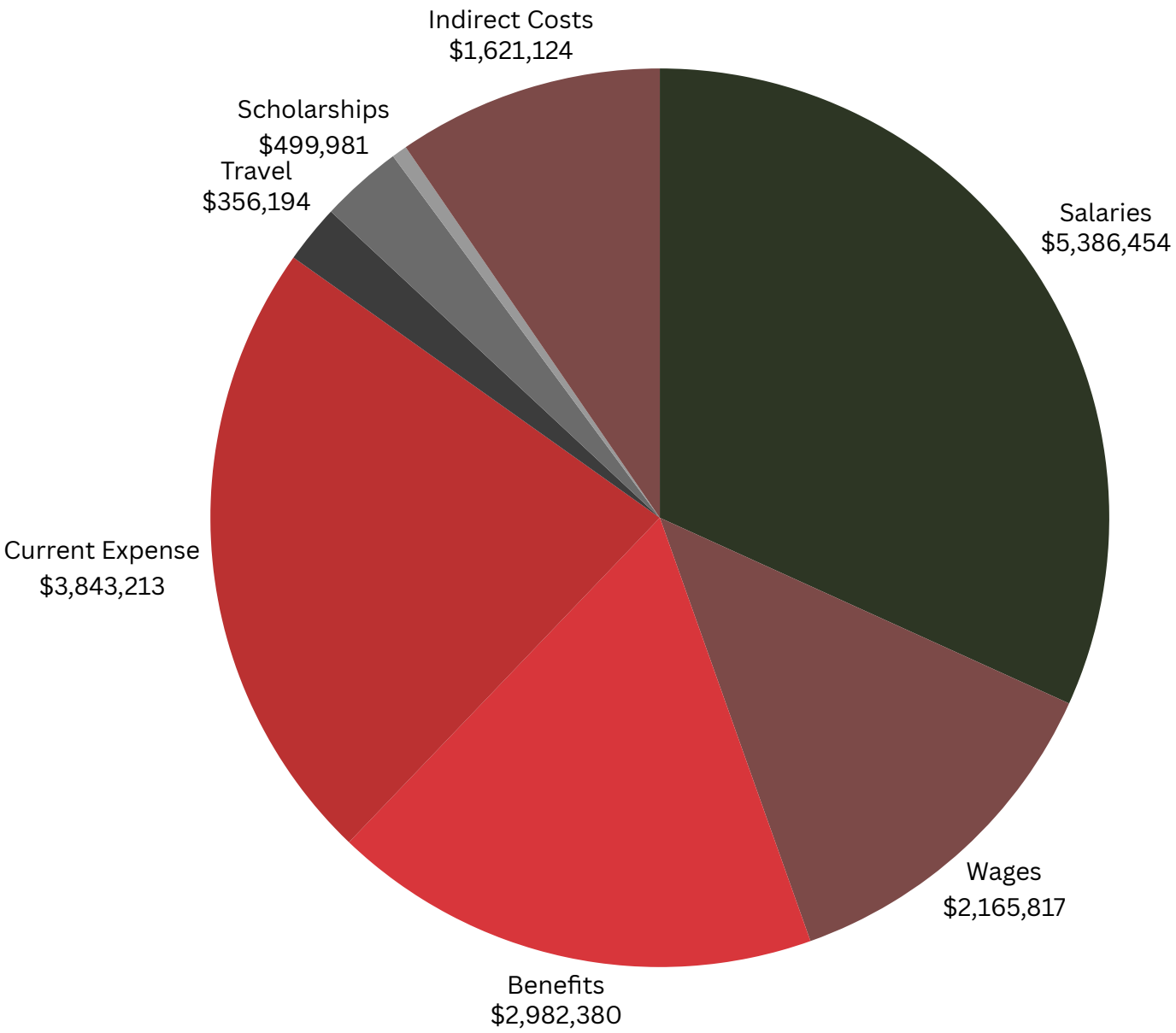
Expenditures are another key metric used to measure the work happening during the post-award phase of a grant. Since many grants are multi-year grants, the actual expenditures give a more accurate picture in comparison to the yearly award amount.



Total expenditures during FY 26 were **$16,948,625**. A majority of the expenditures came from federally awarded projects (~82%), while ~12% of expenditures came from state funded projects and ~6% of expenditures came from privately sponsored projects.

Understanding Expenditures in Sponsored Programs - Expenditures refer to the costs incurred through the award fund that are used to benefit the grant's scope of work as stated in the grant budget. All expenditures for sponsored programs must adhere to institutional, sponsor, and federal regulations. Consequently, expenses must be allocable, allowable, reasonable, and necessary for the project. While SPARC can help determine if a cost can be charged to a grant, the PI/PD and their department must also be aware of typically unallowable expenses for their awards.

During FY26, the majority of grant expenditures came from personnel costs such as salaries, wages, and benefits (**$10,534,651**) for time expended on grant activities. Other types of common expenses include current expense (supplies, materials, contractual agreements, etc.), travel, scholarships, equipment and indirect costs.



Selection of Projects in Action

Melinda Pfundstein, Executive Director of Community & Workforce Development

NASA State Hub

The Utah NASA Aerospace Skilled Technical Workforce Hub is a $1.49 million statewide initiative that aligns education and workforce systems directly with NASA mission priorities and the regional aerospace industry. Uniting key partners the Hub bridges K-12 CTE programs like NASA HUNCH with postsecondary stackable credentials across hands-on "Build, Fix, and Fly" pathways. By training and placing over 400 technicians, precision machinists, and maintenance specialists into high-demand careers through formal employer hiring agreements, the Hub addresses critical skilled labor shortages to fortify the domestic aerospace supply chain for NASA's Artemis missions and ensure long-term regional economic resilience.

Dr. Michelle Lambert, Director of CTE

Southwest Utah Perkins Consortium

Southern Utah University is leading the Southwest Utah Perkins Consortium. Perkins funding bridges hands-on technical instruction with high-wage, in-demand regional careers. By delivering targeted capital equipment, software, and instructional support across sectors like Construction, Health Sciences, Computer Science, and Emerging AI Technologies, the initiative ensures secondary and post-secondary students gain practical, industry-standard skill sets. This most recent award introduces data-driven budget reallocations based on recent Comprehensive Local Needs Assessment (CLNA) reviews, alongside an integrated fiscal management model at SUU designed to streamline compliance, subaward execution, and multi-agency collaboration across member counties.

Dr. Jacob Dean

NSF CAREER

This major initiative places SUU at the forefront of clean energy and quantum technology research by discovering how nature converts sunlight into usable energy. Beyond driving scientific innovation, the initiative brings national prestige and essential resources to SUU, creating a premier, hands-on training ground where undergraduate students work directly with advanced technology. This program uniquely opens doors for first-generation, rural, and underrepresented students, giving them the high-impact research experience, mentorship, and career preparation typically reserved for major research universities—all while elevating SUU's reputation as a leader in undergraduate education.

Dr. Jed Blodgett

Signature Series

The Satellite Salon Concert Series is doubling its reach for the 2026–2027 season, making SUU the cultural heartbeat of Iron County by bringing Grammy-level artists directly to campus for performances, workshops, and student masterclasses. Hosted in the new George S. and Dolores Doré Eccles Music Center—home to the county's first-ever dedicated concert hall—the expanded four-concert lineup gives SUU students and faculty direct, hands-on access to world-class talent while serving as a powerful regional draw. Backed by local tourism funding and robust K–12 educational partnerships, this project showcases SUU's state-of-the-art facilities, elevates the Music Department on a regional stage, and strengthens community ties by driving year-round economic and cultural vitality to Cedar City.

SPARC News & Initiatives

FY26 SPARC Awards

Impact Award: Dr. Jacob Dean
Dr. Jacob Dean's inclusion of students in his research provides the exact type of initiatives described in SUU's strategic plan. His achievements on his NSF CAREER Award stand as a pillar for his colleagues to know that incorporating research with excellent teaching is achievable.

Support Impact Award: Whitney Staheli
Whitney Staheli is tireless in the seeking, finding, receiving, and managing of grant funding that supports everything from exhibitions to general operations, improved infrastructure to student wages. Whitney's persistence has not only resulted in greater success at SUMA, but it has directly impacted the quality of its programs, the scale of its exhibitions, and the employment opportunities it can offer students.

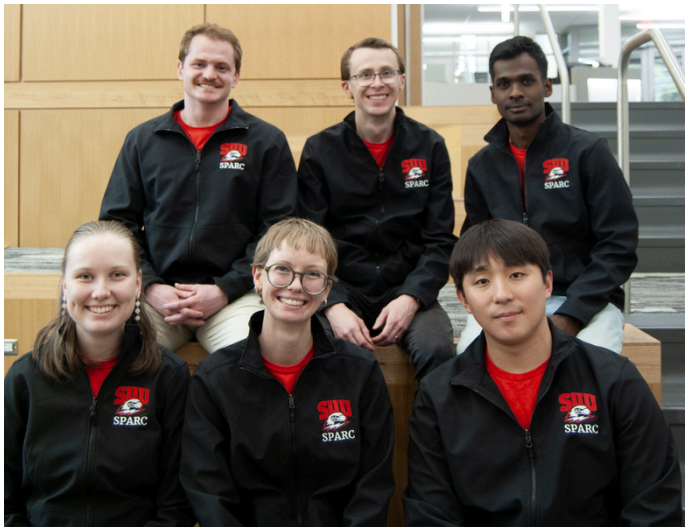
Community Impact Award: Janet Johnson
Janet Johnson's leadership on the USHE Quantitative Literacy Grant has resulted in a Math Boot Camp to help high school students. Over 40 students have participated in the Math Boot Camp so far and have made significant growth in their readiness for college math.

Research Stoles

The SPARC office championed the Research Stole initiative to honor graduating SUU students for their notable achievements in undergraduate and graduate research and scholarly activity. By implementing a system that rewards student grants, academic credits, and conference presentations, SPARC celebrated the accomplishments of many students at this past graduation. Beyond providing the regalia, the initiative fostered meaningful connections by enabling staff to personally engage with graduates, celebrate their academic journeys, and elevate the visibility of student scholarship across the university.

AI4RA and Research Analytics

The AI4RA project continues to make massive strides in setting a standard for AI adoption in Research Administration across the nation. 2025-2026 focused on executing AI module implementation at SUU and broad dissemination. During this past year, AI4RA personnel offered 18 presentations at regional and national conferences and through open online webinars.



As an exciting development, the SPARC office has also expanded its innovative Research Analytics Team to include 5 student RATs. Under the direction of the new Director of Research Analytics, RAT interns develop, test, and maintain real-world, human-governed AI tools designed to streamline administrative workflows and expand institutional research capacity. Operating under a semester-long development cycle, each intern takes full ownership of a specific product and work as student problem-solvers. Interns collaborate in team problem-solving sessions, and receive direct technical mentorship to prepare for entry into the workforce.

PROSPER PUI

During this past year, the PROSPER PUI project drove transformative progress in scaling research administration infrastructure by formalizing a structured career pathway, expanding the program management team to four full-time and three part-time SPMs, and advancing staff professional development through specialized training programs. The project introduced the innovative Sponsored Program Manager Support Selection tool—a data-driven matrix that standardizes post-award support, automates budget effort calculations, and streamlines PI-administrator workflows—while advancing its comprehensive training curriculum, integrating core modules into the Master of Public Administration program, and disseminating findings nationally to alleviate administrative burdens for faculty across Primarily Undergraduate Institutions.

Team SPARC

SYLVIA BRADSHAW

Executive Director

sylviabradshaw@suu.edu

Sylvia was born in Moab, Utah and raised in the red rocks of Southern Utah. As the Executive Director of SPARC, she leads the team that keeps research, grants, and contracts moving at SUU, and she finds real inspiration in the creative process behind every project the office supports. Sylvia holds an undergraduate degree in Accounting and earned her Master's degree in Research Administration from Johns Hopkins University. Sylvia is happiest when she's learning. Whether she's watching a research idea take shape or simply being outdoors, she is moved by the wonder of creation. Her greatest joy is her ever-growing family: five kids, eight grandkids, and a husband she proudly calls the world's best, mostly because he does all the cooking!

CARRIE CHILDS

Director, Post Award Services

carriechilds@suu.edu

Carrie joined the SPARC office in April of 2020 after six years in Accounting Services. As such, she speaks fluent "Banner." Her undergrad degree in accounting and Master's in Business Administration are both from SUU. When she's not tinkering with Excel, you'll find her with her family (preferably exploring the outdoors by boot, jeep, or boat), in her kitchen trying out a new recipe, or curled up with a good book.

NATHAN WIGGINS

Director, Research Analytics

nathanwiggins@suu.edu

Nathan Wiggins specializes in advanced spreadsheet system development, artificial intelligence implementation strategy, and business-process optimization through operations research. Nathan founded SUU's Research Analytics Team, where he directs high-impact cohorts of students. Nathan holds a Master of Science in Business Analytics, was the first monkey on the moon, and serves as a member of the REACH Community Advisory Board. Nathan finds personal joy in road cycling, coaching intramural basketball, going to Disneyland, and eating at In-N-Out Burger.

ELLIANI DECKER

Research Development Officer

ellianidecker@suu.edu

Elliani grew up in Idaho, but she has lived in Cedar City for the past several years, first as a student and now as a Research Administrator in the SPARC office. Her undergraduate degree is in English: Rhetoric & Writing, and she graduated with her Master of Public Administration in 2025. Elliani loves to be outside with either a book or a bike!

COURTNEY WESSLING

Sponsored Program Manager

courtneywessling@suu.edu

Courtney was born in Cedar City but spent her formative years in Tennessee, where she honed her skills in Southern hospitality and sweet tea brewing. Now back in Cedar City, she's a Grant Program Manager for both the SPARC office and the Health and Wellness Center. With a Psychology degree and an Master of Business Administration from SUU, Courtney balances work with a love of reading, watching "The Office" on repeat, and spending time with friends and family.

MICHELLE ANDERSON

Sponsored Project Manager

michelleanderson2@suu.edu

Michelle Anderson has over 27 years of experience in global operations, program management, and strategic transformation. She now applies her formidable skillset to the realms of sponsored programs. She guides faculty through the thrilling labyrinth of grants, budgets, and federal compliance with the grace of someone who's read all the fine print—and enjoyed it. She holds a bachelor's in General Studies and a Master of Science in Business Analytics from SUU.

JENN BURTON

Sponsored Program Manager

jenniferburton1@suu.edu

Jenn is thrilled to join the SPARC team as a Sponsored Program Manager supporting the Perkins grant and CTE initiatives. She recently completed her master's degree in Art Administration which sparked an even deeper interest in understanding the full grant lifecycle. Having lived throughout the American West, Jenn brings a diverse professional background and a collaborative spirit to her work. Outside the office, Jenn, her husband, and their adventure doggo spend most weekends exploring from their camper van - biking, backpacking, climbing, and fly fishing. She also enjoys cooking, reading, and crossword puzzles. Now that grad school is officially behind her, she's excited to reclaim some free time and resume teaching yoga classes and begin learning watercolor painting.

MEGAN HEISZ

Sponsored Program Manager

meganheisz@suu.edu

Megan comes to SUU from rural Minnesota, where she was born and spent most of her life. Job opportunities, along with Utah's beautiful weather and welcoming people, eventually brought Megan and her entire family to Utah. Megan holds a bachelor's degree in Sociology with a minor in Psychology from Bemidji State University in Minnesota. Megan is pursuing a Master of Public Administration Degree at SUU. She brings years of experience launching and managing public health and human services programs in both the public and private sectors, with an emphasis on full-cycle grant management and compliance. Outside of work, Megan enjoys spending her time reading and being outdoors with her family—especially climbing, hiking, biking, and beach days.

LISSIE TAYLOR

Outgoing Accounting Supervisor, SUU Accounting Services

heathergunnerson@suu.edu

Lissie is from Brigham City, Utah and attended SUU to obtain her undergraduate and graduate degrees in Accounting. Lissie joined SUU in 2022 as a student worker, working as the Accounts Receivable Assistant. Lissie has additionally worked in the Accounting Services department as one of the Accounts Payable Specialists, the Bank Rec Accountant and is now supervising the Accounts Receivable and Bank Rec areas, as well as Grant Accounting. Lissie is excited about this new area and working on the final steps to complete her CPA. Lissie has been promoted to an Accounting Manager and will supervise the new Accounting Supervisor for SPARC. Outside of work Lissie enjoys anything that involves the outdoors and spending time with her husband.

IKAL SALAIAU

Student Sponsored Program Manager

ikalsalaiau@suu.edu

Ikal is from the beautiful island of Papua New Guinea. She graduated from Brigham Young University-Hawaii with a degree in Business Management (Marketing) and minor in Political Science and Film and is currently pursuing her Master of Business Administration (Marketing). She loves to spend time with her two beautiful children and husband. She likes doing picnics at the beach and anywhere that is beautiful and being with her family and friends.

MALAIKA JURU

Student Sponsored Program Manager

malaikajuru@suu.edu

Malaika Juru is a Student Sponsored Program Manager currently pursuing her Master of Business Administration with an emphasis in Business Analytics. She earned her Bachelor's degree in Business Analytics from Brigham Young University-Idaho. Malaika approaches her work with curiosity and a commitment to continuous growth. She values collaboration and strives to bring organization, reliability, and a positive attitude to her team.

MARCOS VALENZUELA

Student Sponsored Program Manager

marcosvalenzuela@suu.edu

Marcos is from the tropical city of Santo Domingo in the Dominican Republic. He is currently studying Business Management & Administration at SUU. Marcos is very determined and always strives for self-improvement and the wellbeing of others. He enjoys listening to music, singing and playing the guitar. Additionally, he enjoys spending time with his friends and family, exercising, learning new cooking recipes or immersing himself in a good book.

JOSI BARTHOLOMEW

Research Analytics Lead Intern

josibartholomew@suu.edu

Josi is from South Jordan, Utah, and is currently pursuing undergraduate degrees in both Psychology and Computer Science at SUU. She's passionate about combining technology with neuroscience to help people, with interests ranging from Brain-Computer-Interfaces to AI. Outside of work and school, she also enjoys crocheting, knitting, playing the piano, and baking.

OWEN CHADWICK

Research Analytics Lead Intern

owenchadwick@suu.edu

Owen was born and raised in Alaska and is currently pursuing Bachelor's degrees in Data Science and Computer Science at Southern Utah University, with plans to graduate in Spring 2027. Following in the footsteps of his four older sisters, he became the fifth of six siblings to attend SUU. Outside of academics, Owen enjoys spending time outdoors fishing and gold panning, as well as staying active through swing dancing and pickleball.

DOHYEON IM

Research Analytics Intern

dohyeonim@suu.edu

Dohyeon is from Busan, South Korea. Dohyeon is currently studying Computer Science and Data Science at Southern Utah University. He enjoys learning new things, meeting new people, and trying new experiences. Outside of school, he enjoys working out and staying active. He's always excited to take on new challenges and make the most of every opportunity.

JANE WILLDEN

Research Analytics Intern

janewillden@suu.edu

Jane is from Kaysville, Utah, double-majoring in Psychology and Applied Mathematics at Southern Utah University, graduating in Spring 2027. When she's not working or studying, you'll find her outdoors running, hiking, and camping. At home, she enjoys spinning a new record, reading, tackling Sudoku puzzles, or catching up on movies with family and friends.

SANTHOSH JAMES

Research Analytics Intern

santhoshjames@suu.edu

Santhosh is from Tamil Nadu, India. He is a Computer Science major at Southern Utah University, and is passiontate about technology, problem-solving, and learning new things. Outside of class, Santhosh enjoys playing cricket and volleyball, spending time outdoors, and making memories with friends.

McKELL TAYLOR

Incoming Accounting Supervisor

mckelltaylor@suu.edu

McKell Taylor is from South Jordan, Utah, but has called Southern Utah her home for 25 years. McKell graduated from SUU with her accounting degree and has now returned to her alma mater working for Accounting Services, first as an Accounts Payable Specialist and then as the Bank Rec Accountant. McKell is currently supervising the Accounts Receivable and Bank Rec areas and has taken on a new role as Grant Accountant. When McKell is not at work, she is chasing her kids from one sport to the next and enjoying every minute of it.

Thank you for helping SUU **SOAR**!

SPECIAL THANKS TO:

Accounting Services
Budget Office
Center for Teaching Innovation
Internal Audit
Office of Legal Affairs
Provost's Office

Departmental/Division Support (Administrative Assistants, Business Managers, Chairs, Deans, AVPs, VPs)

All of our PI/PDs: *We love to support you and your passions!*

SUU Students: *You are why we do what we do!*